equals of the post-Stalin leadership group. One of the accusations against Beria was his supposed readiness to capitulate to the West in Germany by abandoning the socialist experiment in East Germany and permitting the creation of a united, ostensibly capitalist but neutral German state.[11]

Khrushchev's second crucial step toward the consolidation of supreme power, a showdown in July 1957 with the majority of the party Presidium, was also closely linked to the German problem. The opposition, led by the diehard Stalinists, was critical of Khrushchev's proposal to provide the flagging East German economy with credits worth three billion rubles. Khrushchev stood his ground. The defeat of the "anti-party" group and the removal of his opponents from leadership positions cemented Khrushchev's hold on power in the Kremlin and his determination to save East Germany from economic collapse at almost any price.[12]

Khrushchev unveiled his own plans for Berlin in a speech he delivered in November 1958 to a delegation of Polish communists. The Soviet leader proposed declaring West Berlin a free city, which would mean the withdrawal of American, British, and French troops. Khrushchev's speech amounted to an ultimatum: if the West did not accept his proposal, he was ready to sign a separate treaty with East Germany, withdrawing from the four-party agreements of 1945 and handing over control of Western access routes to Berlin to his East German minions. That might easily lead to armed conflict between the Allies and the East Germans, and many feared further escalation into a global military crisis and even nuclear war. While preparing for the Vienna summit with Kennedy, he put Berlin at the top of his agenda. His plan was to scare Kennedy out of the city.[13]

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KHRUSHCHEV BEGAN HIS ATTACK ON KENNEDY ON JUNE 3, 1961, with a Marxism-for-dummies analysis of American imperialism and a declaration of his conviction that the future belonged to communism. Although Kennedy allowed himself to be dragged into an ideological debate, he was focused on realpolitik. Referring to "modern weapons," he warned Khrushchev: "if our two countries should miscalculate, they would lose for